MACHINE TRANSCRIPT · CORAGGIO CONSULTING

Virginia House of Delegates Floor Session, Regular Session, Friday, January 16, 2026

Date	Friday, January 16, 2026
Place	Virginia House of Delegates, House Chamber, State Capitol, Richmond
Length	1h 42m (video)

- Official floor video (House of Delegates archive, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bPNGsciz_zg
- LIS House minutes: https://lis.virginia.gov/session-details/20261/minutes-list/H

> Machine transcript (speech-to-text) produced by Coraggio Consulting. Not an official county record. Names and numbers may be misspelled; check the video at the timestamp before quoting.

Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-16. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:11:36] The House will come to order. Members, please take your seats. Sergeant-at-Arms. The House is now in session. All personnel not entitled to the privileges of the four, please retire to the gallery.

[00:11:53] The members will arise and be led in prayer by Dr. Steve J. Collins, Appalachian School of Theology, Nicholsville, and remain standing for the Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America, which will be led by the Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Good afternoon. Shall we pray?

[00:12:12] Gracious and Sovereign Lord, we just want to thank you for this opportunity to gather with these, our fellow Virginians. And what a heritage that we share and what a legacy that we have to fulfill.

[00:12:30] So we come to you today, lifting our members of the House of Delegates up to you because you are the giver of all wisdom. And we ask that you would grant them clear minds and discerning hearts as they make decisions that affect many lives.

[00:12:48] give them strength to serve with integrity courage to do what is right even when it is difficult and humility to seek the common good of all men rather than their personal gain lord guide them with your truth steady them with your peace amid pressure division and uncertainty surround them with wise counsel protect them and their families and remind them that true authority is found in

[00:13:22] serving others well may their work promote justice peace and human flourishing around the commonwealth and even throughout our entire nation so we entrust them to you asking that your will be done in our commonwealth for your glory and for the good of all people in jesus name we pray amen amen

[00:13:51] members will answer the roll call by indicating their presence on the electronic voting board

[00:14:29] clerk will close the roll uh mr speaker a quorum is present pursuant to house rule three i've examined and approved the journal of the house of delegates for january 15th 2026 motions and resolutions under rule 39 pursuant to the provisions of rule 40 are now in order does the clerk have any announcements or communication just one announcement letter from the speaker uh made the following committee assignment changes effective today uh just two uh delegate gardner is removed from the committee on county cities and towns and appointed to the

[00:15:08] committee on public safety also then uh delegate mundan king has removed the committee on public safety and appointed to the committee on county cities and towns sincerely don scott speaker of the house mr speaker remind the body as well that uh three new members will be sworn in on monday so So that will change the committee assignments.

[00:15:26] So it will be a similar announcement on Monday. And then on Wednesday, there will be a special election on Tuesday, so we'll announce further tweaks there as well. In this first portion of the morning, I will speak a request pursuant to House Rule 40 that members use the request to speak button for the items listed on the voting board.

[00:15:44] Delegate from Scott County, Delegate Kilgore. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Rise for an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I hope you'll join with me in welcoming Dr. Steve Collins, who delivered our invocation this morning. Dr. Collins serves as a pastor of the First Baptist Church in Nicholsville, Virginia, has a great ministry all over Southwest Virginia.

[00:16:07] He's the president of the Appalachian School of Theology in Nicholsville, which opened a second location in Uganda this past September. The school in Uganda has over 8,000 students. So we really appreciate the mission work that Dr. Collins and his school are doing in Uganda.

[00:16:28] So he and his wife, Sandy, live in Dungannon in Scott County, Virginia. I hope that you will join me in welcoming Dr. Collins to the house. Welcome, Dr. Collins.

[00:16:51] Welcome to the Capitol today. The delegate from Richmond City, Delegate Cousins. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. in the gallery today, we have the second grade class from Anna Julia Cooper School along with their teacher and chaperones. I ask that they please stand. Anna Julia Cooper School is a tuition-free independent school for K-8 students in Richmond's East End, dedicated to uplifting its students and graduates through an education founded on love. The school is named after Anna Julia Cooper, who was born into slavery in 1858,

[00:17:31] who was an educator, an author, an activist, and one of the most prominent African-American scholars in US history, and who viewed learning as a means of true liberation. In honoring its namesake, AJC provides students with exceptional education, wraparound services, extracurriculars, athletics, summer camps, and graduation support to students into high school and through adulthood.

[00:17:56] I request that members join me in extending a warm House welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:18:15] Delegate from Newport News, Delegate Price. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate, ask the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker, with us today, as is his usual custom. We have the congressional representative for the 3rd Congressional District, who is the ranking member of the Education and Workforce Committee and um a former member of this august body and then got a little crazy and decided to join that other body down the hall but he's a fierce advocate and so i would love for us to give a warm house

[00:18:48] welcome to congressman bobby scott of the third congressional district welcome welcome welcome congressman scott and uh you got the natives riled up this morning pursuant to house rule 30 the

[00:19:27] journal shall reflect that the following members are away on pressing personal business and are granted leave from today's session, Delegates Garrett, Knight, Lauffer, and Runyon. Clerk will announce the next autobiography. Mr. Speaker, in the second portion of the morning hour is not applicable given today's calendar. Same for the third portion of the calendar as well.

[00:19:45] Clerk shall announce the next autobiography. And the fourth and final portion of the morning hour is reserved for member requests for points of personal privilege. The delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Boulevard. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker and members of the body. I'm cognizant that this is a Friday and everybody is excited about the inaugural activities. This is also, I think, my third point of personal privilege in the 20 years that I've been here. My first one was when my

[00:20:20] grandfather passed away. He was a Marine who fought in Okinawa and Iwo Jima as a World War II veteran. The second one was a very, very passionate, impromptu speech I gave on recycling rates. in the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[00:20:36] I know that that's a pretty famous one, and I'm sure people still talk about it today. I've also been around long enough to see a lot of different farewell speeches. And so I've seen really funny ones. I've seen very, very serious ones.

[00:20:53] I've seen ones where there's a lot of unsolicited advice given to each and every one of you. But I also know that the best ones are the shortest ones. And so I'll try to keep this as brief as I can. And that is, after all, it isn't the farewell speech that I will remember or you will remember.

[00:21:12] The exception might be Riley Ingram's very, very infamous farewell speech, which was a tell-all. If you are new to the chamber, you should really go back and take a look. There were a lot of nervous people here on the House floor. But it's the interactions, it's the adventures, it's the laughs, it's the late nights, And honestly, it's the occasional tears that I think we've had together that we will all ultimately remember.

[00:21:41] Mr. Speaker, I remember walking through these doors for the very first time and thinking about the weight of history. And I know you've mentioned that many times, and I think each of us have felt that very same weight. And I also think about the awesome responsibility we have, not just to current Virginians, but for generations after generations to come.

[00:22:04] I look at my children today, the oldest of which were only six and eight when I was first elected. One of them didn't exist when I was first elected. And at the forefront of my mind as I've taken literally thousands of votes sitting in this chamber is what kind of world would I leave for them?

[00:22:24] But those are my children. I think the truly sobering thought is that I and all of us shape the lives of other people's children. Millions of parents and children we will never meet. and that is truly an awesome responsibility.

[00:22:41] I am keenly aware and very humbled that my journey and any successes that I might have had along the way are because of the dedication and efforts of many, many people. To those who have worked so hard on my behalf for the last 20 years, thank you.

[00:22:57] You've made it possible for me to represent the community that I grew up in and the community that I deeply love, and words cannot express my gratitude and my appreciation. Special thanks to my long-term legislative assistant, Rama Van Pelt, who has been here with me for those 20 years.

[00:23:15] He is an incredible partner, the quintessential professional, and he has worked behind the scenes on literally thousands of constituent issues and requests. And so if he's watching right now, thank you, Rama. I want to thank and recognize the incredible House staff.

[00:23:32] Mr. Clerk, you and your team are amazing. To all the fantastic and dedicated people of the Division of Legislative Services who work over the holidays and late into the evening to get those bills right, thank you. Our committee staff are as wonders at keeping things moving along.

[00:23:50] I want to especially thank my General Law's Clerk, George Cain, and our Senior Staff Attorney, Ashley Binns. You made us look really good despite ourselves. And on appropriations, a debt of gratitude to all of our staff.

[00:24:06] But I especially want to thank Ann Oman, Kim McKay, and David Reynolds. I have learned so much from each and every one of you. And then to my amazing wife, Gretchen, my best friend and partner in life. Ever since we first met at Robinson Secondary, I knew that we would have amazing adventures together.

[00:24:27] And when I would have doubts, you were always there to support me, gently pushing me when I needed extra encouragement. You have been a true partner every step of the way, and I'm looking forward to being there for you in your next role. To my children, Alex, Josette, and Grayson, I am very proud of you.

[00:24:45] I know that growing up in a political family is not easy, but I hope you know that it meant the world to me that we did this together. And thank you as well to those who might not have always agreed with me, but nonetheless offered friendship and a different perspective.

[00:25:02] That honest discussion and collegiality have been deeply valued. And one of the most meaningful things that was ever said to be by a member of this body is that while I may not always agree with you, I trust you. And finally, my deep gratitude to the residents of the 11th House District, who have entrusted me to be their voice for the past two decades.

[00:25:24] Mr. Speaker, at a recent event, you mentioned my involvement in the emergency committee, for which I deeply appreciate that you allowed me to be chair of that committee and to take the show on

the road all across Virginia. And then you said, part of the reason for selecting me is because I was as boring as watching C-SPAN.

[00:25:43] Sorry. To which my wife turned to me and said, what's wrong with C-SPAN? We love that channel. Mr. Speaker, thank you for placing your trust with me.

[00:26:00] In closing, I love this house, and it has been an honor to serve with each and every one of you. Thank you.

[00:26:34] Delegate from Chesapeake, Delegate Lefwich.

[00:26:55] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. Delegate, ask the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I'd like to address the retirement of Delegate Bulova. I've known this delegate for a long time. I've worked with him while we had a supermajority. I worked with him while we had a slim majority, I think through a coin toss.

[00:27:15] I've worked with him when the other side of the aisle had a slim majority, and I was actually looking forward to working with him while y'all had a supermajority. I've known him as a member of his committee on general laws, and then he got to be on the committee when I was the chairman of general laws.

[00:27:34] And both of those transitions were very smooth, and I attribute that to his integrity and honesty and trustworthiness. I was struck by something he said when he was getting ready to retire, when he gave his retirement speech. And he talked about the impression or the effect you have on other people's children.

[00:27:54] And I would say to him that he did that best through the way he conducted his life and the way he handled himself as a person and an individual. And lastly, what I'll say is, you know, we're all part of our own little clique and group.

[00:28:10] And when I go home, being a Republican, I hang around Republicans for the most part, the city committee meetings and stuff. And many people come up to me and say, oh, my gosh, you know, what those people are doing in Richmond. I say, wait a minute, hold on, stop. They're good people.

[00:28:27] There are a lot of people on the other side of the aisle that I have a tremendous respect for, even though we may disagree on things. I say they're good people. they believe they just have a different way of approaching that and whenever i said that there was a picture in my in my dictionary of of a few people that uh really thought the most of that that about and the delegate that was retiring is one of those people uh tremendous tremendous respect for this man and i'm very sorry to see him go although i wish him well in his new endeavors

[00:28:59] the delegate from arlington delegate lopez thank you speaker point of rise for a point of personal privilege? Delegate has the floor. What can you say about a guy you've known since high school?

[00:29:30] We all know him, in the elegant words of Delegate Leftwich, as someone who is respected and generous and in the weeds on public policy and the sort of epitome of what a delegate should be. I knew him originally in high school as an incredibly cool rockabilly punk rocker. And if you ask him today, who his best favorite bands are, it'll surprise you. That being said, there's a reason

[00:30:06] why several of us joke, even when there was a super majority on the other side, you could bet your next mortgage payment that David Bolovo was going to pass three water bills in the first 10 days of

session, at least three. And it's because of who he is. Because as we all believe, you can trust him. He gets into the weeds on data. He gets in the weeds on policy. He's talking to all

[00:30:42] parties. And he has a great opportunity, both professionally and personally, and in his public service journey right now. But to say that you will be missed and that you are deeply appreciated is an understatement, a massive understatement. And I hope we all can sort of strive to be the

[00:31:13] kind of legislator that David has always been, which is kind and generous and caring and really in the weeds on public policy and who's coming at everything from a people perspective, not about whether or not it's a Republican idea or a Democratic idea, but whether or not it's a good idea that'll help families in Virginia. And I'm going to cry again, and I'm not going to do that, but thank you

[00:31:51] for your example. Thank you for your friendship. And thank you for all the work you've done in the General Assembly. And may we all strive to be trusted the way David Boulava is trusted. The delegate from Richmond City, Delegate Jones. Mr. Speaker, I rise for a point of personal

[00:32:29] privilege. The delegate has the floor. I haven't been here as long as Delegate Boulava and those that are leaving this August body today. But a good friend of mine said you don't have to be eternal to be effective, and that's the one thing I've sought to do. Without a long speech, the one thing I know how to do is preach from an ancient text, and Mr. Speaker, there's one text that comes to mind, to whom much is given, much is required, but the way it ends, it says, and even more will be

[00:33:09] asked, and Mr. Speaker, that's something you've lived by, that's something that you've done in our time together and my time here in this body. You've always asked more of not only yourself, but all of us, not just Democrats, not just Republicans, but this entire body. I've had the privilege to watch history unfold. And I meant that when I talked about my mother's scrapbook a couple of years ago, that it's a privilege and it's been an honor to be a part of Virginia history, which is a part of your life story. And that is something that has been a guiding light

[00:33:48] in the North Star, as I've dealt with the last session, facing prostate cancer and dealing with that. This is more than just a body of legislators. We've built friendships.

[00:34:05] I was still in Johns Hopkins University Hospital, and two people called me, our speaker and our chair. I was high as a kite. I can tell. But I know that they called, and that is something I will never forget.

[00:34:26] forget and so I appreciate you and all that you do when when when he came to my first launch party he didn't talk about the job that he wanted me to do he just gave a phone number 280-332-281-330-8004 hit Mike Jones up on the low because Mike Jones is about to blow and I knew something was different about this man right there anyone with his position and his aspirations to come in and be that real and that transparent meant something to me because that's something I've tried to

[00:34:59] endeavor to do as a pastor and a politician. To all the leaders, Leader Tran or Leader Herring and Chair Tran, thank you for y'all's compassion and the boot, the gentle boot that would make sure that we were supposed to be where we needed to be as long as we needed to be there.

[00:35:25] To all of those that embraced our class, we looked up to so many of you as we read the newspaper of what's going on in the General Assembly, as we saw what was going on in the Richmond area and the Commonwealth. We looked up to so many of you, and many of you were so much larger than life.

[00:35:43] And it was just, it's been a privilege to just sit next to you and to listen and to hear all of the wisdom that came from your lips, your mouths, to share with how you do policy the right way. To my class, I think I have one of the best classes the General Assembly's ever seen.

[00:36:04] We came in, D's and R's. We had a great relationship, my friend Chad Green. Personal trials, tribulations, he was one of the first ones to call. And even in his absence, I can still recognize and share that he is a friend, someone who I care deeply about and wish him the best.

[00:36:25] Whether it was the powerful speeches that our class did or using sign language to share a deep message, we are a talented and gifted class. And I'm just so glad to be a small part of that.

[00:36:41] You know, going through the whole special election, the whole process, you know, people were concerned with, would you lose? There was no losing. I would either go to the Senate because the vote said so or i would come back to a 64 seat majority that's a win-win and i'm gonna miss that i'm surrounded by chesterfield chesterfield and henrico we didn't have that when i first came in and that's something that we've all fought to do and we've done it together and so i want to challenge you to continue to lead with love compassion and conviction and do the work that

[00:37:18] we've been called to do by those that have voted us into this place. To the constituents of HD 77, I leave you in good hands of Delegate Elect Charlie Schmidt. I've known him for a while, and I'm looking forward to the work that he does, because if he doesn't do it, I'll see him on crossover. And so I wish him the best. I wish him the best in what he has to do. There's an old hymn that we would sing in the church mama mcquinn we are soldiers in the army we have to fight although

[00:37:53] we have to die we have to hold up that bloodstained banner and we'll still hold it up for the day we die i'll see y'all all at crossover god bless you i'm not clapping for you as long you ain't going

[00:38:30] nowhere um the delegate from colonial heights delegate jerry mr speaker i rise for a point of personal privilege the delegate has the floor thank you mr speaker um we have a lot of names we use for each other in this body.

[00:38:48] Some of them good, some of them not. All of us are colleagues with one another because our constituents have sent us into this place to represent them. Many of you over time, we develop into friends because we share those committees, we share those ideals, we talk about the things that we find value in.

[00:39:12] We talk about our shared struggles, our cares. And periodically it goes a little bit deeper than that. And I'll use the term brother for my friend.

[00:39:28] Mike Jones. We bonded over a shared love of sport, whether it was high school football, various basketball teams. We shared life together when we had struggles with our families and with other things that were going on around us. So very rarely is it that we get to get that depth of familiarity with someone in such a short time as we spent in this chamber together.

[00:39:58] But I always knew where he stood. I always knew where he was because we had an open channel of communication, and we would work across that center aisle, no matter the majority, no matter the minority, no matter what the situation or circumstance was. Now, as you said, we're not getting rid of him, Mr. Speaker. You know, many times when we give these farewell speeches, we don't know if we'll ever see that individual again. They may live in a far southwest or north part of the state, and I try not to go north of Fredericksburg if I can help it. But we know

[00:40:34] we're going to see him again, whether that be at the other end of the hallway or at the other end of the bench that he's now on the losing team in the basketball game. So the fact that he's choosing to go to that other august body down the hall, sometimes, Mr. Speaker, when people want to be wrong, you let them be wrong, and you get out of their way. But I say thank you for being my

[00:41:09] colleague, for being my friend, and for being my brother. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Virginia Beach, delegate, ask you. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise to the point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, you know this versus him pretty well.

[00:41:40] I'm quite sure that the delegate from Richmond knows it too. So I'm going to start my speech with a question to the outgoing delegate. And I'm sure he's heard a lot of times in 20 years. I'm going to do a little help, a little crowd participation. So, who? Mike Jones. Who? Mike Jones. There we go, there we go.

[00:41:56] Or better known as, in the future, as Senator Mike Jones. Mike, while you will no longer be in this chamber, you won't be too far away. As you just stated, we'll see you at Crossover. While in this body, you fought to protect our communities by banning auto seers. You fought to protect our athletes at practice by making sure they were hydrated and protecting them from exhaustion.

[00:42:19] You worked to protect our communities, Richmond, from a lot of traffic fatalities, as we've seen over the past few weeks and lost community members. But Mike, you've always been a listener ear. You will no longer be around the corner for me to bother you and steal your sodas, but I promise you I'll be down to talk about life and for you to mentor me as an older brother, and I greatly appreciate those conversations.

[00:42:42] You know, we thank you for your continued service to this Commonwealth from your time on the City Council to your time here in the House of Delegates. And we will miss you here in this body. So thank you again. Thank you for your service to work with you. A lot of members here will be bothering you as it comes close to crossover.

[00:42:59] And we appreciate your kindness as we head into that. And you said is I don't I hope you don't mind if I give out your number for the for the Commonwealth again. But if you ever need to reach him, again, that's 281-330-8004.

[00:43:15] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Sickles.

[00:43:35] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. Delegate has the floor. Thank you. My first advice to everybody is don't leave on the same day as these other great people leave on. It is not good. I wanted to say something about David, Delegate Boulevard, because I sat beside him several times.

[00:43:56] And for the new people, he read every bill. He knew every bill. So I cheated a lot. He told me what it was about. I had a million questions for him. He never got tired of answering them. So anyway, good luck saving the environment and doing all those good things you're going to do for us.

[00:44:14] He's wanted to do this his whole career, and now he's going to get a chance to make a big difference. To Delegate Jones, we've sent a lot of delegates down the hall. It hasn't helped yet.

[00:44:28] So maybe you're the one. Maybe you're the one. I hope so. So as as Delegate Bulba said, I've listened to many of these speeches over the years. You will not remember this and it will be mercifully

short. I've been here a long time. I was appointed to Delegate Lacey Putney's P&E committee in 2004.

[00:44:57] He was such a gentleman. At the first committee meeting, he told us why P&E was not only the first committee, but also the most important committee in the General Assembly. Everything else flows from our elections. Delegate Putney stayed for 22 years like me. Then he stayed another 30 years after that.

[00:45:17] One farewell speech I remember was your predecessor a few times removed, Mr. Speaker. I had not been here that long when Kenny Melvin announced he was not running again. I was bummed because I saw the difference he could make in our deep minority.

[00:45:36] He left after 24 years here. And I have to have a lot of people to thank, many on the other side. Speaker Howe put me on appropriations when we only had seven members on our side.

[00:45:51] So I know how that feels. I feel for you. I don't feel that bad. I spent 18 of 22 years in the minority. It's a lot less work if you want it to be.

[00:46:09] And in other ways, it's harder because you need to work harder to get things done. So good luck over there. As a reminder to those who ask how we did it all those years, we did some very important things in a minority.

[00:46:25] For example, our votes were critical, telling you to talk to our side over here, to the passage of Speaker House transformative transportation legislation 2013. That could not have been done without Democrats on our side.

[00:46:41] the bill would not have emerged from the Finance Committee without Democrats. The Speaker, this is a secret, don't tell anybody, but the Speaker lobbied our members to get the votes to get it out of Finance Committee. And if you want to know what a difference that bill has made, there's a guy named Nick Donahue getting on board soon, and he will tell you, because he is an encyclopedic, has an encyclopedic knowledge of everything.

[00:47:04] It has been transformative for our state, for the economics of our state, and we're still benefiting from it every day. And, of course, Medicaid expansion in 2018, when we had 49 on this side, what a difference expansion has made for not only the working poor in Virginia, but for every person in the Commonwealth, because in health care, everything is related to everything else.

[00:47:29] And that's what we learned, and that's what we're, unfortunately, having trouble with now, understanding as our historically low uninsured rate is threatened. Didn't mean to put that policy stuff in there, but I thought I'd take a shot anyway. These were great achievements, but I wouldn't trade these victories for the progress we made in our majority for anything.

[00:47:53] I'm looking forward, Mr. Speaker, to watching all you can do over the next at least four years with this historic administration that will be sworn in tomorrow. I'd also like to thank, as my colleague Boulevard did, Chairman Torian and the outstanding staff on the 12th floor for the education of a lifetime.

[00:48:14] For those of you new to appropriations, it is a different committee. If you are unhappy, if you don't get your way or your perfect bill, you should immediately ask the Speaker to put you on another committee. You can go to county, cities, and towns or something.

[00:48:31] Well, sorry. Well, I mean, I know that's a tough committee, but it's not quite the same. When I started, former Chair Chris Jones welcomed any legislator who would do the work.

[00:48:51] The budget is largely bipartisan. Nobody in either party wants to waste precious General Fund dollars, so it is always an annual opportunity to work together. So, Mr. Speaker, I will miss serving you in this body, serving with you in this body, or serving you, too.

[00:49:09] And thank you for all your kindnesses. And I've said before, if you can get the ice cream machine working downstairs, you will see me more often. So, thank you. And a shout-out to my current chief of staff, Andrew Millen, in the gallery for all the work you did.

[00:49:27] All my former aides seem to be doing a lot better than I ever did, and I'm proud of all of them. So thank you, Mr. Speaker, and good luck.

[00:49:53] Speaker.

[00:50:16] The delegate from Falk Hill County, Delegate Weber. Mr. Speaker, I rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate at the floor. I've got to gather what I was going to say because Delegate Sickles did such a great job.

[00:50:36] Mr. Speaker, over the course of the time that I've been here, I've gotten to know quite a lot of people. A lot of people, you don't realize, the longer you are here for the newbies, you will see how many people come and go.

[00:50:54] Before and after, and when you start looking at your license plate number, you're like, all right, did he come in after me? Did he come in before and after? You know, you're like, all right, well, after today, I move up two more slots. Just saying. There's still somebody else, I believe, that's also going to step away today, too.

[00:51:19] So I'll try and do all of them that I can real quick, because I will tell you some lessons that I learned from each of them. And when I first got to this body, someone told me to get to know all 100 of your colleagues because each of them will teach you something.

[00:51:37] And I've tried to take that to heart. And there's 100 of us, so it gets a little difficult, I guess. You have to do it over time. But my classmate, Alfonso Lopez, about David Bolivar was absolutely correct.

[00:51:54] I still remember coming in. I think I carried five bills my first year. That's why I was. And I got one through. One. Small government Republican. Just saying. But I watched David stand up, I'm sorry, Delegate Bolova stand up, Mr. Speaker, and it would be a slew of bills right before crossover.

[00:52:14] And I'm like, how did he get all this stuff done? And it's because he always chose projects that just, they were needed, they were bipartisan, and they were for his district. And he would just, it was local issue after local issue after local issue.

[00:52:34] And I think what I learned from that was when you pick issues, we're going to have issues that we're going to battle over. But always find an issue where you can reach across the aisle and get to know your colleague because at some point there's going to be issues that we're going to come together on, period.

[00:53:00] For Delegate Sickles, I will tell you that if I ever wanted to get into the minutiae on the budget, particularly with health care, I would, when you were sitting where Vivian is sitting, I would stop and spend about a half an hour.

[00:53:17] But I will tell you that when it came to any program and you wanted an honest opinion about what it was going to do or what money was needed or any of that, it was always Delegate Sickles that I could trust to get back to Delegate Bolivar's issue.

[00:53:40] Now, I'm going to talk about Mr. Jones. I don't know why you want to go down the hall. And Delegate Sickles is absolutely right. We have sent a number of delegates down there, and it still doesn't help us. But congratulations. You have conducted your business with fortitude and reason, and I look forward to seeing that further.

[00:54:07] And if I could, Mr. Speaker, I would like to address a delegate that I battled with on a number of different occasions.

[00:54:25] Not as much as Nick Freitas battled her. But it was always in committee, either Commerce and Labor or Labor and Commerce, depending on which side you're talking.

[00:54:42] Or Melissa Police and Public Safety when she first got here. but I will tell you that the partisan rancor that you see today and that we experience in this body at times, I, this summer, reflected on her loss. And I will tell you that despite the fact that we, as I posted, fought like cats and dogs, it was always those moments at 11 o'clock at night

[00:55:21] working on energy bills or doing something else where you found the humanity that we miss when you literally watch television and I will honestly say that I learned a lot from you.

[00:55:37] I learned a lot from every single one of the members that are leaving this body and I learned a lot about tenacity and strength and I will say that each one of us in this body whether you're here as long as Doug at Sickles in Bolivar which is a long time or you decide you want to go across the aisle or down the hall the history of this body the average person will never

[00:56:09] see. But the impact that we have will last forever. And it was Delegate Torian that this summer basically said even if you're here for a short time, you can leave an impact. And I have a feeling we're going to be seeing the impact from this summer, this session. So Mr. Speaker, I just have to say thank you to my colleagues. Thank you for your service. And thank you for the education that

[00:56:46] you gave me. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Tran. Thank you so much, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Thank you.

[00:57:15] When I first came into this house, Delegate Sickles was assigned to be my mentor. How lucky was I? He was your mentor too? How lucky were you and how lucky were all of us to serve alongside him and to learn from and work with him. But first, I just want to make a note that Delegate Sickles started off his comments today about his own retirement from this chamber, speaking about others and lifting up the work and the successes of his longtime colleagues and I think

[00:57:53] that's all we need to know about his generous spirit and his quick wit. We have had a chance to work with one of the very best, someone who dives deep, very deep in policy, who asks tough questions, who understands the art of working across the aisle and who delivers some pretty good zingers. And as chair of HHS, we know of his deep passion for expanding affordable health care and making sure that children and families have the support they need to be well and to thrive.

[00:58:32] He had an incredible hand in Medicaid expansion, in establishing the Virginia Health Benefits Exchange, implementing the reinsurance program. But as much expertise as he built, intentionally built

over time in health care, he was so generous in helping all newbies on that committee get up to speed and making sure that we were also successful in our legislative endeavors.

[00:59:00] Delegate Sickles has also had an indelible impact on voting rights. He's been a staunch defender of ensuring that every eligible voter is able to make their voice heard at the ballot box, leading on expanding mail-in ballot access and emergency voting options. And he was one of the first two openly gay members of the General Assembly. His presence, his voice, and his courage in fighting for equality has paved the way for so many legislators in the General Assembly today,

[00:59:32] many of our own colleagues. Mr. Speaker, Mark has shown us, all of us, that yet again in our hallowed halls, leadership can be different and still be transformative. And I was incredibly moved to hear his passion and his fire as he fought for spreading happiness this week and making sure that our Constitutional for Marriage Equality passed, which is truly inspiring.

[01:00:11] On a very personal note, and equally importantly, Delegate Sickles has become a friend to my whole family. And as I was scrolling through all my texts to him, there are the pictures of him with my son on the steps of the portico on January 2018 when Medicaid expansion was signed into law.

[01:00:34] There he is on his own with a bunch of my kids at a Nats game. There he is joining my family in Manassas to hear my son play in his orchestra concert. He's just shown up for my kids and given them support in immeasurable ways, and I will always be grateful. But that's who Mark is, Someone who cares about policy, but someone who cares about each and every one of us as individuals, and someone who cares very deeply about the people of Virginia.

[01:01:07] He is a true servant leader. So today, make sure you have a scoop of ice cream as you celebrate Delegate Sickles' service. We appreciate you deeply. We will miss you so much, but we're glad to have a friend in the Patrick Henry building. Thank you.

[01:01:25] Delegate from Bartitott, Delegate Austin.

[01:01:59] Mr. Speaker, I rise for a point of personal privilege. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I can't let this moment pass without speaking about my good friend, Delegate Sickles. Delegate Sickles and I have, when I came to this body, my side aisle had a 67-seat majority.

[01:02:16] I sat three seats in on that side. I quickly learned by looking and listening and watching and observing my colleagues on both sides of the aisle, the people that I should pay attention to. And one of those individuals was Delegate Sickles. Anytime Delegate Sickles rose on the floor, he rose with passion in his voice.

[01:02:34] He rose trying to convey an important message that he felt sincere about in his heart, and I realized that, and I took notice of that. And since that point in time, as serving on appropriations, he and I have ping-ponged back and forth as vice chair of appropriations.

[01:02:52] And, you know, as officers got turned over, we did it cordially and kindly and respectfully, And Delegate Sickles and I served quite a bit of time there as conferees. And what I witnessed as a conferee was Delegate Sickles cared more about the underprivileged and people who really needed what Virginia should be delivering and his passion for that.

[01:03:16] And back home, when I would receive calls about Medicare, health care, Medicaid, my go-to person was Mark Sickles. I never hesitated to say to my colleagues at home, I'm going to give you a number

and a name, and I would like for you to reach out to this individual, because I can't give you the advice and counsel as well as my good friend, Delegate Sickles, can.

[01:03:39] And I often, the reply back to me was, they would call me back, and they would say, I really appreciate the counsel and advice that I've received from your colleague. And they said, but isn't he a Democrat? And I said, did that really matter? It didn't matter.

[01:03:55] The advice and the counsel that they got served them well. And that's just the type of person that Delegate Sickles is. And so, you know, Delegate Sickles, I've often asked, when you come to our part of the state, you have a bedroom in my home anytime you want it. You're welcome there, and you always will be.

[01:04:12] And it's nice to know you're not far away because I tell you, we don't have the people that we need, the knowledge that you have accumulated over time. And that's a problem in this body and in other bodies. We're losing so much accumulated knowledge. Delegate Boulava has a tremendous amount of accumulated knowledge on water quality.

[01:04:32] And since he's been appointed, I've heard more about the loss of knowledge that he will be taken with him. And just yesterday when we left his chamber, when he and his incoming bride and I walked down the hall, I said, I hope you will be a friend and stay in tune to the water quality needs of Virginia.

[01:04:50] And he assured me that he would. And I have no reservation of that, that his heart's there. So, to Delegate Jones, I've enjoyed serving with you, my friend, I welcome you at the other end of the hall. That's not always the best place to be. I don't understand. As I said to you in the members' lounge yesterday, our food's far better over here.

[01:05:08] And so, just ask Delegate Bagby about that, and he will attest. I told him I would meet him at the door with a plate any time. So, I'll do the same for you. Yes, sir. So, anyway, thank you to all my colleagues and Delegate Sickles.

[01:05:26] Your friendship is invaluable to me, my friend. It's meant so much. Thank you. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Roanoke, Delegate Russell.

[01:05:50] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Point of personal privilege. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I think that's the first time I've heard one of these speeches where they throw shade directly on CC&T. And Chairman Helmer, these are, and this is definitely, Mr. Speaker, the fakest goodbyes I've ever heard.

[01:06:14] I'm carrying a bill for Delegate Bulova's daughter. His wife is going to be here in just a few minutes. And don't you know, Mike's going to be down the hall voting against our bills. And I know the Secretary of Finance is going to just say, there ain't enough money in the budget.

[01:06:35] But to Delegate Austin's point, Fifty years of knowledge is leaving this house in a very, very short period of time, and it's a lot. I would be remiss not to just, I think, say the sadder part of it is I know, David, it would be awesome to have your father here with us.

[01:06:57] And I know he's watching down and, of course, Candy, your beautiful daughter. But, you know, Mr. Speaker, especially being from Roanoke, sometimes we get hit for being a little bit too nice, as some people say nice.

[01:07:15] But the wonderful people that we have that are leaving, Mr. Speaker, we know that there are some good stories about how nice people can do some great things. So we wish you Godspeed as you move forward. Thank you so much for your leadership. Delegate from Prince William, Delegate Mundin King.

[01:07:46] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, the word of the day is... He got nervous.

[01:08:04] You're supposed to be a nice farewell. Be nice. I'm going to be nice. Mr. Speaker, the word of the day is gratitude. When I came here five years ago, I stood right here with my amazing husband, wonderful children, and I was sworn in to represent the people of Prince William County.

[01:08:28] And I would often say, I'm here for a good time, not a... That's right. And I had no idea how good that time would be. Believe it or not, I got into a lot of trouble when I was first elected. And it wasn't always good trouble.

[01:08:46] But when I think back about what we've been able to do, when I think about the momnibus, when I think about Mia's Law, When I think about the sickle cell reforms that we've been able to make and the work to support survivors of human trafficking, we have done that together.

[01:09:05] And for that, I am forever grateful. And to my colleagues on the other side of the aisle, thank you for the debates, the compromises, more importantly, the prayers. My prayer partners don't have D or R beside their name.

[01:09:26] They've lifted me up in ways that I couldn't even think was imaginable. So thank you so much. And to the incredible people who make this place run, all of the staff, from the clerk's office to appropriation, and especially to the janitors and people who bring us food, the people who do the care work of which I am a descendant.

[01:09:52] I would call them out by name, but they wouldn't like that. but I am so grateful to serve alongside them as well because I know who makes this place work and I am so grateful to them for giving us the support that we need. And to the people of the 23rd District, you have given me one of the greatest honors of my lifetime. Every time I cast a vote, every time I get up here and get the gavel banged at me for saying something out of

[01:10:24] order. I am doing it with deep love and gratitude. And now to you, Mr. Speaker, you have been there for me to pick me up and to carry me. And there are those in this body who know who they are, that I don't think I would physically be here without you. I'm grateful. And to all those who

[01:10:56] I offended. To all those who I offended, most of them ain't here anymore, but to all those who I offended, just know that I do it again. And I do it again, not out of malice, but I do it again

[01:11:27] because I am the child of Elma Lee Williams. I am my grandmother's child. I am my grandmother's child who only had four years of schooling and had to work on as a sharecropper as an eight-year-old child. I am the descendant of women who are smarter than me, who are more hardworking than me, and who have never been given the opportunity to serve in places like this. So I will, I do it again. I do it a thousand times because they deserve to have their voices heard. And most importantly, I do it again

[01:12:05] because I know that just like she did here on earth, there's a little girl in heaven saying, "Get 'em again, mommy, get 'em again." So to all of my colleagues who don't get the privilege of continuing to

work with Chairman Boulivre and work with Chairman Sickles, I'm sorry.

[01:12:27] But as I go on this journey, I'm so grateful to this body for accepting me, for making me better, and for serving this commonwealth. And while my seat at the table may change, my heart will always be here.

[01:12:43] So thank you all so much for the love, the kindness, the prayers, the support. And I know that this body will continue to be the conscience of the Commonwealth. Thank you all so much.

[01:12:57] Delegate from Scott County, Delegate Kilgore.

[01:13:36] Mr. Speaker, rise for appointed personal privilege. Delegate, that's the floor. Mr. Speaker, ladies and gentlemen of the House, I rise to say to Delegate Mundan King, we're going to miss your passion. You know, we all come here, I've been here quite a while now, but we all come here representing 88,000 people.

[01:13:54] We may not agree on a lot of issues, but we all need to have the passion that you had representing your district. And I, for one, appreciated your passion and appreciate your passion going forward. you know, the one thing we can say about the house, being in the house, that we're family.

[01:14:14] And, you know, we cried with you, prayed with you, prayed for you during your time of loss. And we're all better people for it. And we're better people that you came into our life. It was great to get to know you on Commerce Committee. We served a lot of late nights together getting some of those bills in shape.

[01:14:35] And you brought a lot to the table. And for that, I really appreciate what you were able to do in your short time. But I'm very excited also about where you're going. I can finally get appointed as a notary public. I've always wanted to do that.

[01:14:53] But, you know, I appreciate you got me. All right. But about Mark Sickles, Delegate Sickles, you know, as Terry Austin just said, You know, this is the guy that I always went to because we had a lot of issues in Southwest Virginia on health care, a lot of issues on Medicaid, a lot of issues on funding-free clinics.

[01:15:15] And he was my go-to guy to figure out whether something could be done or not. And a lot of times he took care of it for me, just fixed it. And for that, I'm going to be eternally grateful to you for stepping up for Southwest Virginia.

[01:15:32] And now he's going to be on the Tobacco Commission, Mr. Speaker. So we're looking forward to having him there. And to David, just appreciate you. You're just one of the nicest people here. And you always took my advice to be nice.

[01:15:47] And you always did that. And you're right. You always had all these bills coming up. And we'd be sitting here and I'd be, well, I guess it's, I don't even know what it's about. But I guess I'm going to vote for it because it's about water, and we trust David Boulevard to know what he's doing and not leave me down the wrong road.

[01:16:09] But we appreciate your service. And, Mike, you're going to the other side. I just don't understand why you wanted to do that. This is the best body. I've had opportunities in the past to do that. I decided this is the people's house. This is where things get done.

[01:16:26] This is where the rubber meets the road. But we look forward to working with you on your journey. And, you know, all our bills when they come over are not bad. But just remember that. Just remember your friends over here when you get there. But, Mr. Speaker, we all have a lot to be thankful for.

[01:16:45] And we all have a lot to be thankful for that these ladies and gentlemen crossed our path during our service here in the Commonwealth. So thank each and every one of you. Thank you.

[01:17:05] I was just discussing with the clerk that I'm going to make an exception because normally morning hours is one hour. But because all these jokers are leaving, I guess we've got to let y'all talk a little bit more.

[01:17:23] So the clerk and I have decided to make a small exception. The delegate from Newport News, Delegate Price, but don't get used to this. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. Delegate, that's the floor. Thank you. Very quickly, David, every time I listen to an Eagles game on Sears, there's a bank that says, "Brilliantly boring."

[01:17:48] And I just think that that is so appropriate, but it has kept you out of trouble and got you on appropriations and got lots of your stuff passed. But I made some assumptions about you being boring, and I'm so glad I was on General Law so that I could get to know you, because you are quite hilarious.

[01:18:06] And I've had a really good time getting to know you. So thank you so much for what you've taught me while I was on your committee. My boy, Bob, we will see you next week. Mr. Chair, I cannot imagine being one of the first two of anything until you live it.

[01:18:37] And then you realize the immense pressure that comes with that. And I was sitting in this row. We were fighting about something. It was probably marriage equality. And you were very transparent on the floor at a time where it was still dangerous.

[01:18:59] And we didn't know that this current moment was coming where it would be dangerous again. And that inspiration helped me to stop faking pronouns of my loved ones and to be unapologetically who I am and show love in the way that I need to.

[01:19:17] So not only have you changed our lives, but we are, today, before you and Adam leave, the LGBTQIA caucus is at 10, a historic 10 today. And we could not get to 10 without trailblazers.

[01:19:32] And I remember our first conversation, it was after my first floor speech, and you said, well, maybe try a softer approach. I did not heed that advice, but I encouraged you to be snarkier.

[01:19:49] And we got it. We got snarky Mark. So as H.J. 3 has passed the Senate today, it will go to the voters because of you. And we thank you.

[01:20:07] Mr. Speaker, a lot of people know I never came here to make friends.

[01:20:30] And you've done a good job. I've succeeded. Except, gosh darn it, if this lady from Prince William County didn't come and make me love her. And it is because of the care and concern that I watched her give to each of us on both sides of the aisle. And you never know how much care you need until you lose a loved one while

[01:21:02] trying to be a delegate. And I watched her be there for me. And I just did not understand what was going to happen next or if I was coming back and, you know, all of that. So when she gained an angel.

I knew that I had to pay it back. And there's no way you can really repay someone for saving your life, but you got to try. And so I tried to use all my training and be there.

[01:21:41] And I just realized that the sisterhood that we have formed, Mr. Speaker, goes way beyond position. goes way beyond the work that we do here the pride that i have in her every single time she gets up to speak on this floor to tell the truth and it might be in words mr speaker that this room has never heard before uh or in ways but that is the beauty of the authenticity and the unapologetic

[01:22:13] nature of our dear friend so um our angels are so proud of you and my mama used to text me all the time wondering how Mr. Speaker could deal with two of us and I and I hear recently that you were texting my mama too but um she was telling me to get you straight yes you still trying I'm sorry

[01:22:42] We're going to work it out. We're going to pray it. But our families have become family and Delegate Mundin King will forever be in my heart. I'm so glad we still get to work together in her new capacity. But there is relief that comes with her announcement as well, Mr. Speaker. Maybe some of you all can stop congratulating me on going to the administration.

[01:23:14] Maybe some of you will remember I represent Newport News and not Prince William County. But being confused with Delegate Mundin King is one of the highest compliments that I could get. And lastly, I am really, really going to miss the audible groans from across the room every single time she gets up to speak.

[01:23:39] So with that, Mr. Speaker, I wish my friend, my sister, my spirit animal, and my soulmate a wonderful, wonderful, wonderful journey in her next chapter. Thank you.

[01:24:06] Delegate from Fredericksburg, Delegate Cole. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. Okay, the rest of y'all just get two bars.

[01:24:24] All right, Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Well, what do you say about a woman who is able to say everything for herself and who's able to stand on her own two feet, her own? In 2016, when I was contemplating running for office, I reached out to a young man by the name of Joshua King, because I thought he was my candidate at the time.

[01:24:46] And I reached out to him, and he was like, no, you're not in my district, but maybe you should run for office. Why don't you come to my house and meet my family? So I kept getting these invitations to their black history dinners that they would have at their house. And I would see his wife running around the house doing the thing that a proud black mama would do.

[01:25:02] So a couple of years later, when I heard that House District 2 was going to be empty, I called Josh King and said, you're going to run, right? He was like, no, but let me call you back tonight. So he called me back tonight and he said, my wife is the one who's going to run. And I watched her.

[01:25:18] I knew what Candy could do, but I didn't know what she was bringing to the table. I found out that she comes from the heritage and the legacies of Senator Yvonne Miller, that she had already worked in these halls and that she was the wisdom behind Josh King in all his races.

[01:25:36] And then we served together. I watched her fight. And I'll never forget the first time she introduced a bill on the virtual floor. in 2021. I don't remember who it was, but one of our colleagues on the other side of the aisle thought they were going to trip her up and she ended up tripping them up. We

came back in 2023 and I loaned my chief of staff to her because I thought I was going to come back anyway.

[01:26:00] And the first time I won in 2023, I got a phone call. The first person to call me that night, Mr. Speaker, was Delegate Candy King. She didn't tell me, congratulations, welcome back. She said, you can't have James back. And then I watched her fight, stand on this floor and usher the omnibus bill, usher legislation for sickle cell reform in the Commonwealth of Virginia, a work we still have to do. And then we all saw what happened over the summer when Candace was

[01:26:33] promoted from glory. And I watched as this mom said that she was going to take a break and focus on her family. But she realized that the people of the 23rd district could not have a break. So even in her mourning, she continued to do the job of a delegate. I'm excited. The fact that in 2021, Mr. Speaker, for the history that we had in Stafford County, there has never been a black woman judge to sit on the bench in the entire 15th Judicial Circuit. And it was because of

[01:27:10] Delegate Mundin King that we were able to appoint the first black woman judge in the 15th Judicial Circuit. I'm excited, Mr. Speaker, that as she moves from here over across the street, that black girls all over the Commonwealth of Virginia, nope, black girls all across the United States, because people see your videos, they know that they no longer have to be quiet. They know that they no longer have to sit down and wait their turn because they've watched Madam Secretary do the good work, and they know because of the life that she lived, well-behaved women

[01:27:48] rarely make history. And as she said today, as she sits in this chair for five years, and I believe in biblical numerology, five is the number of grace, that as she leaves here to go across to the Patrick Henry building, that as she fights to restore rights, as she fights to listen to people's stories. And as she fights to appoint the right people to positions, that Virginia will have such a grace because she's in the room. And then as I take my seat as a good preacher closes, I'm reminded

[01:28:22] of the book of Proverbs where it talks about a virtuous woman. And it says she is clothed in strength and dignity. She can laugh at the days to come. She speaks with wisdom and faithful instruction is on her tongue. She watches over the affairs of the household and does not eat the bread of idleness. Her children and her husband arise and call her blessed, and her husband praises her. Many women do noble things, but you surpass them all. Charm is deceptive, and beauty

[01:28:57] is fleeting, but a woman who fears the Lord is to be praised. We honor you for all the things your hands have done, and we let your works speak well of your name, and we will watch you with great interests as you continue your fight from one building to the next we thank you and we look

[01:29:17] forward to the great things you have yet to do thank you mr speaker delegate from alexandra delegate harry thank you mr speaker i rise for a point of personal privilege the short version very short mr speaker yes they heard they they their heads all night they're feeling great they

[01:29:56] just floating right now go ahead thank you mr speaker dedicated passionate grounded and steady These are four words that describe four extraordinary individuals who will be leaving. Delegate Mike Jones, your dedication is clear.

[01:30:15] Your dedication to your community and your dedication to public service. We wish you the best as you go to the other body down the hall. Grounded, David Bolova, thank you for your friendship to all of us in this chamber.

[01:30:33] Thank you for your intellect and telling us when our bill needs to be improved. We are so lucky that you will be serving still the Commonwealth of Virginia. Thank you. Mark Sickles, you are steady.

[01:30:52] You're steady in your friendship. You're steady in your legislative experience and being a policymaker. And yes, you love ice cream. And thank you for just sharing all that you know with every member.

[01:31:10] And we are so lucky to have served with you and that you're going to continue to serve the Commonwealth. and Candy Munden King, passionate, passionate and intellect combined is what you are. There is nothing that is going to stop you. And as a phrase goes, unlike what you said, you are your mother's daughter. Continue all that you have done. Continue the work on sickle cell anemia. There is a reason

[01:31:46] for everything. And in your heart, you're carrying your daughter, but you're going to carry so much more, and you carry the hope and the dreams of so many, so many children here in this Commonwealth. Do good. These people, Mr. Speaker, represent the best of what the Commonwealth has to offer.

[01:32:09] They represent the best of public service and public leadership. Godspeed to each and every one of you. Delegate from Arlington, Delegate McClure, the 99th delegate to speak on this subject today. I rise for a point of personal privilege, Mr. Speaker. The delegate has the

[01:32:45] floor. Mr. Speaker gave me the, I know the hour is late and he gave me the look and the pleas for brevity. So I will try to be short, but there are four really important individuals who have really shaped who I am today. And so I'll try to be brief and thanking them and showing my gratitude.

[01:33:03] Seeing as I'm sitting in her old seat, most has already been said about the great delegate from Prince William County. Candy Mundan King was elected when I was serving as executive director of the Virginia Legislative Black Caucus. And I remember the moment she came in and I knew there was something special about her then.

[01:33:21] She has fought so many battles in here and I will miss her fire floor speeches. And I know many of you watching will as well. But she has also fought many battles that those of us have seen and then those of us have not seen. And she has still showed up with such a passion and with a smile and such kindness to so many across the aisle and on this side of the chamber.

[01:33:44] And I just want to thank her and show my gratitude because I have called her many times to confide in her, to, you know, the word of the day is trust. And I trusted her so deeply with so many things. And she was there for me as I became a first-time mom, which is extremely hard to do when you are serving in this body.

[01:34:04] So I don't know how I would still be standing here without you. So I really, really thank you for having such a heart of gold to every single person who has come to you. You have shown such care and compassion. And I know that you're not going too far, so I'll try not to be too sad, but I just wanted to thank you for looking out for so many people and looking beyond yourself so many times, so thank you.

[01:34:24] To Delegate Sickles, he represents my mom. She is in his district, and so I thank you so much for taking my calls, the many calls that I have had with you about health care, about transit funding, and

so much more. And I also want to thank you and show gratitude for allowing so many people to be seen, to feel seen through your leadership in the many years here in the General Assembly.

[01:34:48] So thank you. To Delegate Boulava, I have had the honor of serving on General Laws, and I served as a member of staff for seven years, and I have watched your leadership throughout the General Assembly and have deeply admired you from afar. So being able to serve under your leadership as chair, I served on three subcommittees.

[01:35:06] And Delegate Bulova sat in every single subcommittee meeting. And I had the honor of sitting right next to him and picking his brain on a number of different things and nerding out over policy line by line. So thank you so much for the leadership that you've shown there. And to Delegate Jones, thank you so much for your dedication and your service.

[01:35:25] And it has been an honor to come in with you as classmates and seeing you shine And then for some reason, make the choice to go to the other side of the hall there and serve in the body that you're likely starving. Because I don't know if you know, but they don't have food over there.

[01:35:42] But I will kindly bring you a plate if Mr. Clerk doesn't give me a look. So congratulations to all. I know you all are not going very far. But I will deeply, deeply miss you and your institutional knowledge and your passion in this body.

[01:35:59] So thank you so much. And I hope that was brief enough, Mr. Speaker. and giving not brief enough, so thank you. You tried.

[01:36:21] The delegate from Hampton, Delegate Ward. And the last person in the queue, thank God. All right, thank you, Mr. Speaker. That's okay, that's all right. I don't mind being last. Mr. Speaker, I'm speaking today about the gentleman Mark Sickles.

[01:36:37] Something special about him, Mr. Speaker. We came in in the class of 2004, the best class that has ever graced this chamber. Mr. Speaker, I want to let you all know something special. Six governors have come. Six governors have left. We've had five speakers that came. We have four speakers left. When we came in, there were 100 members. Mark and I have seen 95 of them leave.

[01:37:14] But I always thought that there would be a Sickles and Ward team. Mark and I even talked all the time. He was one number all for me. You know, we pulled numbers. His number was one number higher than me.

[01:37:30] And I would always let him know that he was more, you know, junior to me. And he would always remind me about the way we pulled those numbers. I've never forgotten Mark. But there would always be a Mark and Sickles.

[01:37:45] I mean, a Ward and Sickles team. mark would always at every uh governor inauguration we took a picture together and all of you who know me for a while you all know i don't do steps well so when we would go down for um during those during those inaugurations mark was always there to help me you know the ms thing but he would always be there to make sure so i told mark that he could never leave he could never leave me and that's when we had this agreement that when I left, when he left or I left, we would both leave

[01:38:23] together. And Mark, you know, we almost did, but I want to congratulate you and thank you. And you know that I told you, what did I tell you? If you ever left and left me here, everybody was going to

say that poor Juwan, she what? She has no class. She has no class, but thank you so much, Mark, for always being by my side. I appreciate it and wish you the absolute best. Love you, Mark.

[01:39:10] Clerk will call the calendar. Mr. Speaker, calendar for today, Friday, January 16th, 2026, day three of this session. Mr. Speaker, there are no, there is not any business come before the body. Per House Rule 51, the House is returned to the morning hour. Does the clerk have any additional announcements or communication? Yes, sir, Mr. Speaker. I simply remind the body that budget amendments are due to House Appropriations staff by five o'clock, so you need talk with appropriation staff if you're working on a budget amendment looking ahead to the rest this afternoon there are no meetings legislative meetings official meetings going on which I am aware Jordy leader will talk a little

[01:39:50] bit about her gathering tomorrow obviously I would ask everyone for an email I sent before if you would remain in your seats at the end of this for five minutes so I can share a little bit of information with you looking ahead to Monday, January 19th, Martin Luther King Day, Lobby Day, Chairman Rasool, Committee on Education, meeting at 8 a.m. in House Committee Room A, down in the lower level, Committee on Communications, Technology, and Innovations, meeting at 10 o'clock, up on the second floor in House Room C, the Democratic caucuses meeting at 10 a.m. in, excuse me, 11 a.m. in House Room 1, probably going to call. He's at 1115 1115

[01:40:30] and House Room 2. Ms. Speaker, that is all the answer I have at this time, but I ask you to stay if you would, please. Delegate from Alexandria. Delegate Herring. Mr. Speaker, I move that when the House adjourns today, it adjourned to reconvene on tomorrow at 11 a.m.

[01:40:48] Delegate from Alexandria. Delegate Herring moves that when the House adjourns today, it adjourned to reconvene tomorrow at 11 a.m. As many as favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed. Delegate from alexandria delegate hearing mr. speaker i move that the house do now adjourn that from alexandria delegate hearing moves that the house do not adjourn as men in favor the motion will say aye those opposed no motion is agreed to the house turns adjourned until tomorrow at 11 a.m

